

Black Americans, Originators of Soul Food and Louisiana Creole Cuisines

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Abstract

Historians wove folktales around chefs assembled near a cast-iron cauldron. After Portuguese traders visited a lavish Louisiana estate, the French stirred the roux. In the moment, Choctaws infused sassafras flavor, while Spaniards drizzled olive oil into the African-simmered okra. Once the work of fiction faded under the light, culture bearers with an ancestral mosaic appeared—Black American Creoles.

Archival evidence—historical cookbooks, documented practices, and legendary master chefs—support the development of unique dishes and barbecue techniques. The research addresses erasure in origin stories and centers on the evolution from obscure agricultural environments to the global culinary stage.

Introduction

From stark slave quarters to stately plantation kitchens, agricultural geniuses raised chickens, cultivated plants, honed culinary techniques, and crafted a unique world-class cuisine. Cherished crops—the seeds of soul food, thrived in harsh weather, rose from diverse soils, and echoed boundless strength and survival.

Chefs published the first cookbooks—*Hotel Keepers, Head Waiters, and Housekeepers' Guide*, Tunis Campbell, c. 1,848 CE. *A Domestic Cook Book*, Malinda Russell, c. 1,866 CE, and *What Mrs. Fisher Knows About Old Southern Cooking*, Abby Fisher, c. 1,881 CE.

LeRoi Jones coined the term “*soul food*,” which described a collection of dishes mastered for nearly half a millennium, c. 1,962 CE.

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Collard greens appeared in ancient Greece, 800 BCE. Egyptians and Ethiopians recorded the early use of okra, and later, Europeans wrote of okra in West Africa and watermelon in Northeast Africa. Europeans imported collard greens, okra, watermelon, and black-eyed peas to the Americas and exported peanuts, along with tomatoes—species native to the Americas—to Africa.

Rice cultivation began in China, c. 7,000 BCE, and in Africa, c. 2,000 BCE. In isolated regions unrelated to the masses, the Gullah Geechee cultivated Carolina Gold Rice and preserved remnants of African religions, folklore, and crafts.

Far from a global flatbread, cornbread elevated maize as a leavened savory cake. Artisans crafted leavened biscuits, gravy, mashed potatoes, pastry dough, and meats fried in seasoned batter.

Middle English defined animal intestines as “*chitterlings*.” Peasants in medieval Europe consumed the whole pig, while commodified captives turned pork scraps—chitlins, feet, ears, and knuckles—from sows’ ears into silk purses.

Since antiquity in the Americas, wild game, flavored by wood ash, wild onion, sassafras, or sumac, braised in hickory oil, and nut milk—cooked over open fires. In bondage, children stoked labor-intensive 24-hour fires and smoked meats guided by elder “*pitmasters*” on plantations. Barbecue halls of fame awarded Black Americans for grill techniques, woods, flavors, and traditions.

Archaeology shows an independent evolution of cheese production in ancient Egypt, Mesopotamia, Greece, Rome, and the Indus Valley. Medieval Italy documented the use of flour to craft pasta noodles. Willed to Thomas Jefferson, James Hemings, “*Father of Macaroni and Cheese*,” apprenticed in France, perfected cheeses, sauces, meringues..., and reigned as the first master chef in America.

Chef and restaurateur, George Speck or Crum, fried potatoes into “*Saratoga chips*.” George Washington Carver innovated over three hundred uses for peanuts.

Augustus Jackson, a White House chef, enhanced ice cream. Nathan “*Nearest*” Green, a master distiller, mentored Jack Daniel. Richard “*Dickie*” Wells, owner of Wells Supper Club in Harlem, paired waffles with fried chicken. Biscuits, gravy, battered meats, ground peanuts, dressed poultry, pastries, fermentation, and distillation originated in ancient Egypt, Greece, and Rome.

Thanksgiving evolved from North American harvest festivals. Cranberries, corn, beans, and pumpkins, paired with European feasts centered on stuffed poultry and gravy. Soul food celebrated, innovated, and elevated the elements of seasonal holidays.

In Afrocentric mythology, women sensed seizure and tucked dried okra seeds into coiled braids. While the captured lay covered in the filth of dungeons, African guards chained limbs, shaved heads, and violated bodies. After brutal months-long voyages, spirits dimmed on Caribbean

islands. As the weary passengers touched Louisiana shores, seeds slipped from bare scalps into fertile soil, and gumbo emerged.

European traders adapted the words okra and gumbo from *Ila* in Yoruba, *ókùrù* in Igbo, *kingombo* in Bantu. Okra or ground sassafras leaf, *kombo/kompo* in Choctaw, *filé* in French, thickened gumbos, soups, and stews in Louisiana Creole cuisine. Portuguese, Spanish, and French culinary traditions surfaced in the Americas—gumbo, paella, jambalaya, and French colonial Africa—*thieboudienne/ceebu jën* /jollof rice.

In West Africa, the French used broken rice from Indochina into Africa to replace *Oryza glaberrima* with *Oryza sativa*. Faced with a shortage of barley, Penda Mbaye, a Wolof/Waalo-Waalo cook for a colonial governor, prepared *thieboudienne/ceebu jën*/jollof rice. Before colonization, West and Central Africans combined bushmeat, insects, reptiles, fish, vegetables and flavors, fermented locust beans, oilseeds, potash, Guinea pepper, and red palm oil in single vessels—one-pots, c. <500–1,000 CE.

Academics overlooked Black Americans and bestowed the concept of soul food on Africans, based on okra, an East African vegetable, and black-eyed peas imported from West Africa by Europeans. In stark contrast, Europeans designed cuisines and desserts around tomatoes and cacao, absent the obligation to praise ancients in the Americas. Black Americans transformed ingredients from the Americas into the distinctive cuisine—soul food.

Descendants of the British Isles rebranded soul food as “*Southern cuisine*.” In the book *Notes from a Young Black Chef: A Memoir*, West African Chef Kwame Onwuachi connected West Africa to soul food. Foreign-owned restaurants serve African and Caribbean dishes described as soul food. In Europe, Africa, and the Caribbean, historians recorded cuisines outside the scope of soul food traditions.

Homage to Soul Food

Hushed voices mingled as a sleepy sun rose over the Deep South. From the corners of America, four generations crossed the threshold into an ancestral home. Family and friends united to celebrate, preserve, and cook traditional soul food.

Around the kitchen, garden gems glistened under the water. Wise hands trimmed, chopped, and marinated the leaves in an elixir of smoke, vinegar, olive oil, garlic, salt, and pepper. With the flames on low, a slow quintet of pots boiled the collard greens, black-eyed peas, pinto beans, snapped green beans, and rice. Nearby, a cast-iron pan baked cornbread batter into the color of rich amber.

Bold and unapologetic, chitterlings presented an earthiness reminiscent of the tilled land toiled by the ancestors. Once cleaned, the innards boiled for hours in a broth of garlic, onions, vinegar, salt, and hot pepper. The complex nature heightened as a second wave of spices followed. Behind the malodor, the laborious booty settled into a one-of-a-kind aroma, enhanced by a shot of hot sauce.

Dough kneaded and cut into rounds, baked into flaky biscuits. Silky gravy formed from flour thickened with roasted meat juices, sautéed mushrooms, herbs, onions, salt, and pepper.

As the water rippled and swirled, potatoes surrendered to the boil. Once cooled, chopped, and headed for parallel fates, some whipped into creamy, fluffy clouds of mashed potatoes. Others blended into potato salad with a medley of chopped boiled eggs, mayonnaise, relish, and mustard, finished with a sprinkle of salt and pepper.

When the batter hit the hot oil, hisses, pops, and crackles built excitement in separate heavy pots. Whispers of thyme, basil, and celery met the roars of paprika, garlic, onion, and pepper. Mustard and salt cut through to a ginger undercurrent. The first savory crunch of crisp, fried chicken and fish hinted at the tender succulence hidden beneath.

The drama unfolded as bland macaroni pasta baked, bubbled, and melded with velvety cheeses into a bronzed, crisp-topped crescendo—a symbol of comfort amidst the chaos in a spectacle of textures.

Outside, the grill smoldered under the hall-of-fame barbecue chef's critical gaze. Exotic smoke billowed in the air as wood chips—hickory, oak, mesquite, and a touch of applewood—burned. When heat from the wood rose, the barbecue chef used hand-crafted dry rubs and secret sauces for prime cuts with aphrodisiacal flavors and superb sears.

Leaves blazed in sepia shades of crimson, gold, and sienna. Sweet potatoes bathed in luxurious maple, butter, brown sugar, and spices—brewed into a caramelized potion. Tart cranberries softened by cinnamon, nutmeg, and cloves, invited a breath of vanilla to round the center. Orange zest and a splash of lemon juice danced around the fringes. Beneath the cobbler's gilded glazed crust, juice from harvested fruit erupted. The cornucopia captured the abundance of fall. Palms pressed and folded the supple dough. A wooden pin rolled away the rough borders. Below the scalloped edges, a delicate auburn potato whip rested.

Ambient sweet potatoes melded into a crumbly pastry. The interplay unlocked seasonal memories, an aftereffect. Inside the oven, cubes of dried bread, dusted with herbs and sautéed with onions, celery, garlic, salt, and pepper, absorbed the juices from a sun-burnished bird.

Sounds of laughter from loved ones moved closer and closer to the grand table. An ornate brass and crystal chandelier illuminated the room. Soft glows cast chance shadows to set the scene. High-glossed bowls held stacks of layered biscuits, gossamer puffs of mashed potatoes, and spirals of silkened gravy. Beige button-tufted chairs lined up to the plates, silverware, glasses, and linen napkins.

In a trio of enamelware, fried chicken, infused with four-dimensional herbs and spices, balanced the cool character of potato salad and the fiery temperament of barbecue.

Across the table, earthy greens and pearls of rice accented the mounds of beans and odorous chitterlings. Slices from the stuffed turkey lay fanned out on a polished platter. Hot cornbread radiated the scent of toasted butter downwind. Macaroni and cheese, crowned with an umbered crust, added to the ambrosial mosaic. With lemons squeezed and fruit punched, glass pitchers poured icy drinks.

Coffee and desserts—autumnal-themed sweet potato pies, fruit cobblers, and tart cranberries replaced the empty spaces. The clock stopped, spun backward, and then forward as a wide lens closed on a euphoric soul food feast.

Louisiana Creole/Cajun

A starry night awakened to streets lined with Mardi Gras scenes. The holy trinity—onions, bell peppers, and celery—sautéed. Enameled pots of rice and tomato sauce simmered gently. Pungent wafts of smoky andouille sausage and cayenne pepper warmed the atmosphere. As the roux darkened to the rich pigment of chocolate, a mélange of rice, meat, and herbs paired with fresh seafood embodied the depth of the briny Gulf. The elements orchestrated a symphony with neon bursts of flavor. An antique cast-iron stove acted as a stage effect to magically transform nature's bounty. Thoughts drifted, moments lingered, and the notion of time faded. As the kitchen hummed, aromas meandered around the rooms.

In the rear of the Victorian home, loved ones gathered to dine. A fragrant banquet awaited on a rustic table, framed by high lattice-back chairs. Jazz bands followed by carnival revelers thrummed faintly in the background. Over the wrought iron trellises and through the French doors, a sultry breeze seduced with the heat of a forbidden kiss.

Diners traded stories, followed by quiet sips of honeyed tea, Sazerac, or gin cocktails. The silence ended as ladles of gumbo, jambalaya, red beans, and dirty rice passed from pots to plates. A parade of Southern belles spooned puddings and sliced handcrafted pies and cakes. After the desserts and coffee, family and friends flowed toward the parlor. As the last candles waned, the essence wove into the spirit of Louisiana

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